

Directions and locations

Teaching guide

Help someone locate a place or an item.

Understand the distinction

Use north, south, east, and west for compass directions. Northeast combines north and east. On a map, check the orientation rather than assuming the top is always north.

Use top, bottom, left, and right to describe positions on a page or object: in the top-left corner; at the bottom of the page. A place can be in the north of a country or north of another place; these describe different relationships.

Compare the patterns

WITHIN AN AREA

The town is in the north of the country.

It lies inside the northern part.

RELATIVE POSITION

The station is north of the park.

Compare the station with the park.

ON A PAGE

The address is in the top-right corner.

This describes a page position.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Which direction combines north and east?

2. Where is something described as at the bottom of the page?

3. Does north of the city mean inside the city?

Use it in your own life

Give two clear directions to a feature on a page or map.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. northeast

The two compass directions combine into one word.

2. Near the lower edge of the page.

Bottom describes a position on the page.

3. Not necessarily. It gives a position relative to the city.

In the north of the city explicitly places it inside the city.

One possible response

The station is east of the park. Its label is in the top-right corner of the map.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-19.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Give two clear directions to a feature on a page or map.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.